

couple months' salary on the engagement ring. Why? No reason. It's just a brilliant marketing ploy. Mysteriously, that sum has been notched up to three months' salary. The genius idea has become that if your guy buys you a crappy ring, he's not valuing the relationship as much as he should. I'm telling you, the engagement ring racket is a load of crap. It's a made-up concept. Don't fall for it.

Want to be romantic? Tell your bride she'll get a very nice ring on your tenth anniversary, if your marriage survives that long. Buy your hubby a set of golf clubs or cuff links on your fifth. That's when it'll really mean something, and, if you've planned wisely, you'll have the cash to splurge and pay in full. Meanwhile, a simple wedding band should suffice. Nothing says romance like wisely investing the money you would have blown on an engagement ring.

Savings: \$1,000–\$10,000.

2. **Bands at weddings suck.** Go with a DJ at your wedding, not a live band. Why? Wedding bands suck. Worse, they cost a lot more than a talented DJ, or your music-savvy cousin. And please have mercy and ban the quartet playing near the ice sculpture. A quartet just forces drunk people to talk louder. Also, about your ice sculpture: If I see it at your wedding, I'll put a blowtorch to it. There is no greater waste than spending thousands of dollars you can't afford on frozen, Cupid-shaped water.

Savings: \$1,000–\$5,000.

3. **Skip the honeymoon.** Who says you have to go on a honeymoon? Again, this is an expense that, when analyzed, isn't entirely necessary. Go only if you have the money to do so. But remember, you pay a premium for the honeymoon packages and suites, because travel agents and hotels know that your flight times are often fixed, and you're going to be arriving in a "bliss bubble" and therefore be vulnerable to all sorts of add-ons during your special time. Forgo the champagne baths and